

Impact Studies Report

Team Building for Green
Organizational Behavior in Rural Areas

2025

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Acknowledgment

Foreword

Word from the Project Partners

The TB-GOBRA - **Team Building for green organisational behaviour in rural areas** project was born from a shared belief that sustainability and collaboration are deeply interconnected. By combining creativity, teamwork, and environmental awareness, the project has provided adult learners and educators with new ways to build skills that are both practical and meaningful.

Throughout the project's implementation, our partnership was composed of **EUth Wonders e.V. (Germany)**, **University of Lapland (Finland)**, and **Igor Vitale International (Italy)**. The consortium has worked collaboratively to develop, test, and validate an educational methodology rooted in green values and participatory learning.

The Impact Studies and Mini-Research Report represent the final phase of this journey. This publication gathers both quantitative data and qualitative insights collected during the piloting of our methodology in Finland and Italy. It aims to assess how effectively the **TB-GOBRA** approach fosters teamwork, environmental awareness, and inclusion within vocational and adult learning contexts.

By presenting evidence-based results and reflections from trainers and participants, this report serves not only as a validation of our work but also as a tool for educators, VET centers, and community organizations wishing to implement sustainable team-building in their own contexts.

We hope that these findings inspire others to integrate creativity, green practices, and collaboration into their teaching and training activities helping to build more connected, conscious, and resilient learning communities across Europe.

The TB-GOBRA Partnership

EUth Wonders e.V. – University of Lapland – Igor Vitale International



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Practicality Concept



How to impact study is made

A total of 26 participants took part in a series of workshop pilots focused on developing team-skills through the implementation of sustainable crafts, the following data presented is part of a methodology developed by the international project TB-GOBRA. The multi-background and multi-cultural participants volunteered to take part in the impact study, where they were asked to take proficiency tests prior and following the workshop pilots. 20 of them answered the test after the experience.

In addition, the participants studying at the University of Lapland were asked to reflect on their experience, we received 17 essays. The participants who answered the questionnaire and wrote the essays were partly the same and different. In addition, observations of the activities from the facilitators and documentation of the craft processes and results are used as research data.

General Feedback

The feedback highlights the participants' positive experiences with the workshops, emphasising the friendly, inclusive, and supportive atmosphere fostered by professional and approachable facilitators. Many found the activities enjoyable, insightful, and engaging, offering opportunities to learn about sustainable crafting, traditional Finnish techniques, and collaborative practices. The workshops helped participants socialise, break the ice, and discover shared interests, enhancing their sense of community. However, a recurring suggestion was the need for more explicit workshop descriptions, objectives, and information on post-workshop requirements to help participants make more informed choices. Some participants noted that improved clarity in instructions during the workshops would also enhance the experience. Overall, the workshops were described as valuable, inspiring, and worthwhile, with many expressing interest in more frequent opportunities for similar activities. Several participants discovered new hobbies and appreciated the use of natural and sustainable materials, which were seen as both beautiful and environmentally friendly.

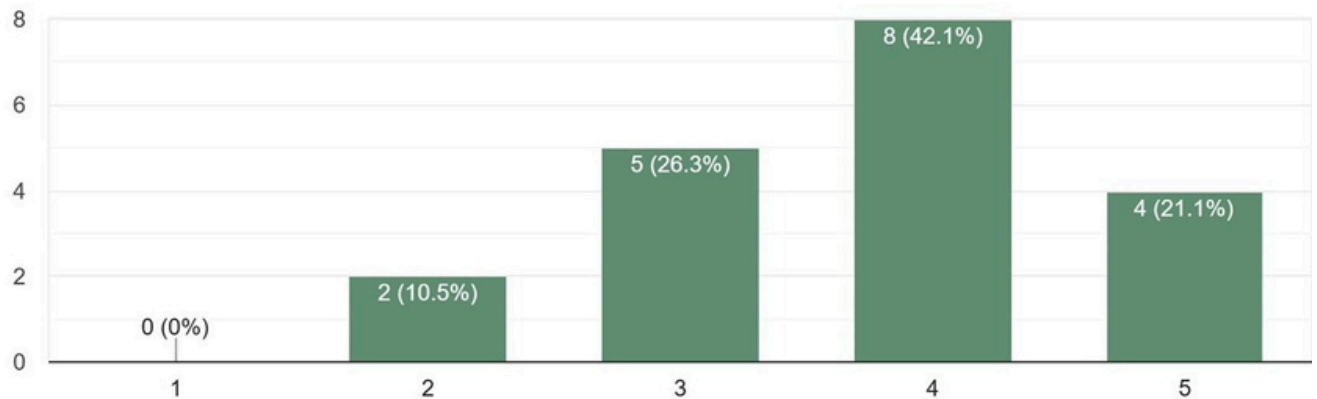
**Positive
Impact of
TB-
GOBRA**

77%

General Point of View

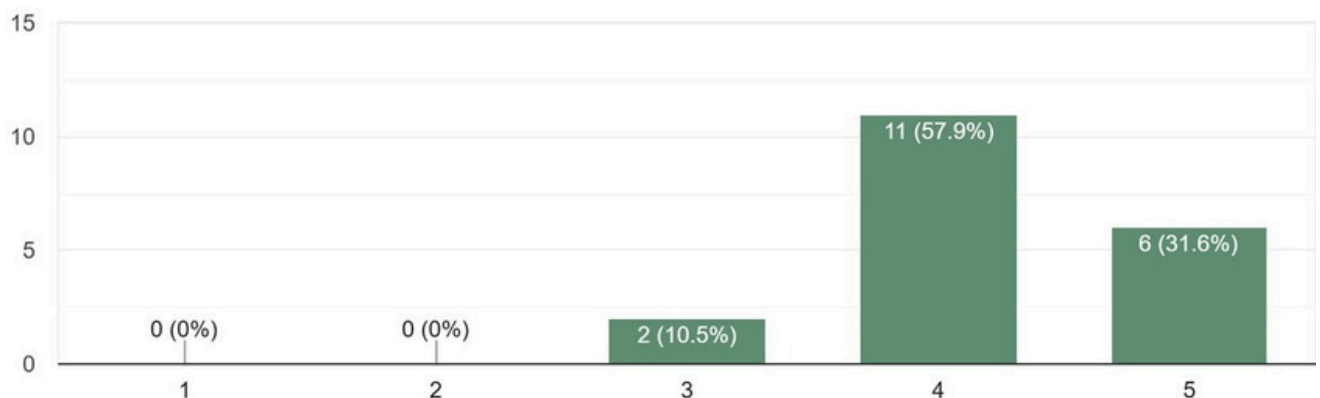
1. The methodology increased my capacity to work as a team leader

19 responses



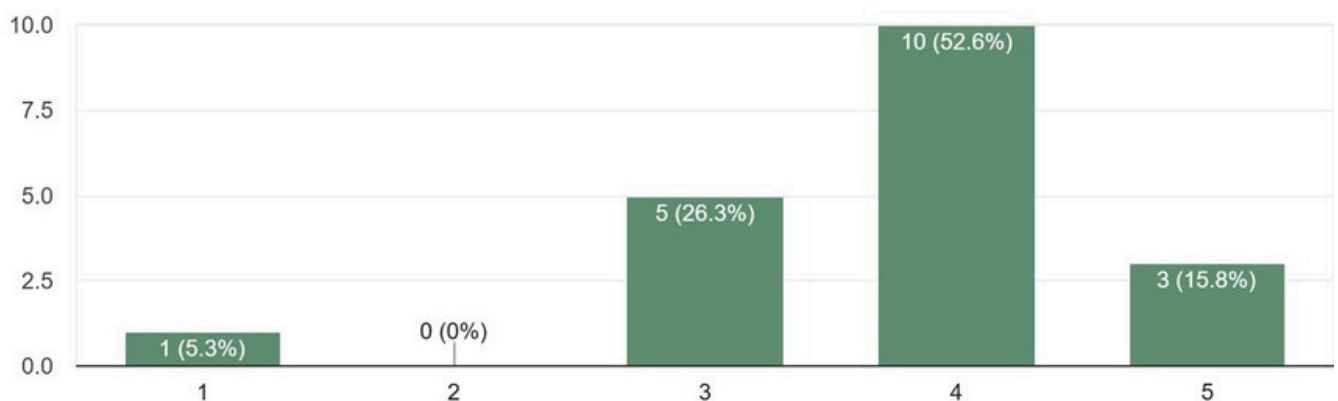
2. The methodology increased my capacity to communicate in team groups

19 responses



3. The methodology increased my green skills

19 responses



FIGURES 1-3: ON SCALE 1 (MINIMUM) - 5 (MAXIM), THE METHODOLOGY INCREASED PARTICIPANT CAPACITY TO WORK AS A TEAM LEADER, COMMUNICATE IN TEAM GROUPS AND INCREASE GREEN SKILLS MOST ON LEVEL 4. THE IMPACT ON COMMUNICATION IN TEAMS WAS EXPERIENCED THE HIGHEST.

4. The methodology increased my awareness concerning the importance of environmental sustainability

19 responses

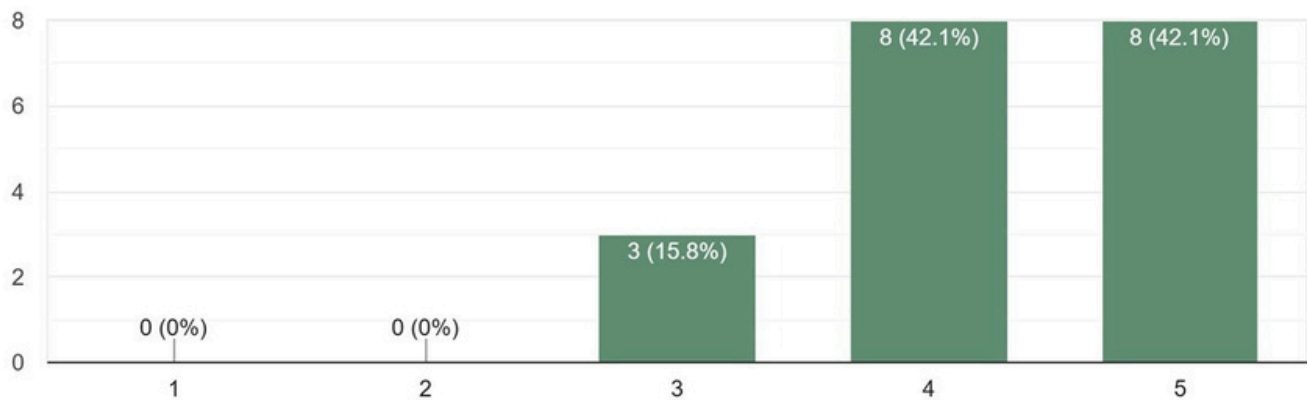
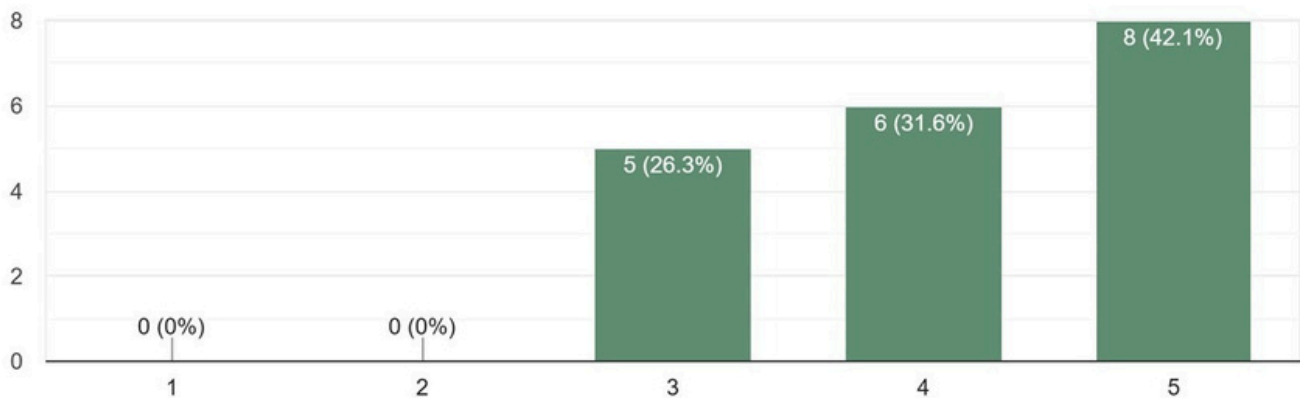


FIGURE 4: THE PARTICIPANTS REPORT A HIGH IMPACT OF METHODOLOGY ON INCREASING AWARENESS CONCERNING ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY. ON SCALE FROM 1 (MINIMUM) TO 5 (MAX), 42% REPORTED THE IMPACT ON LEVEL 5 AND OTHER 42% ON LEVEL 4.

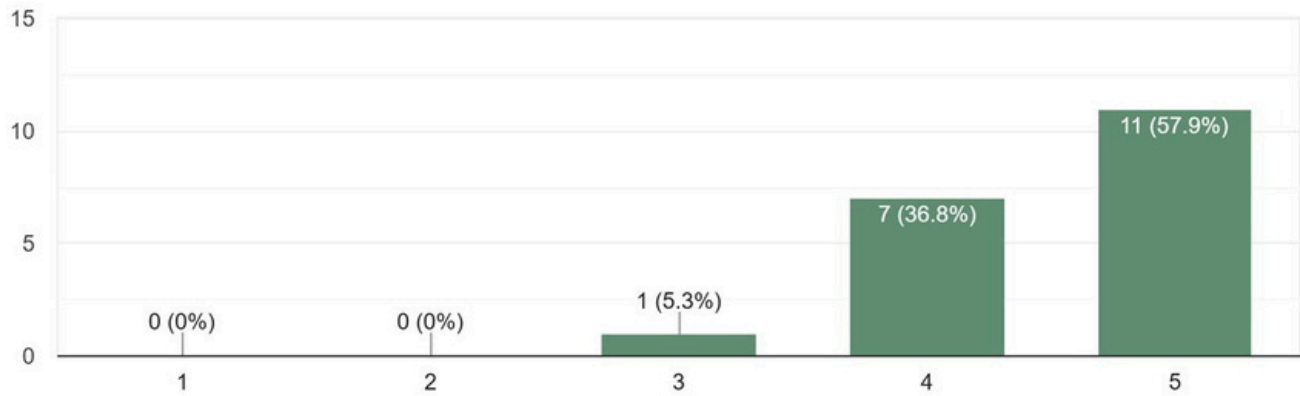
6. The methodology is effective for supporting team cohesion

19 responses



8. The methodology is effective for supporting positive emotions in the team groups

19 responses



Point Of Review

P1

The atmosphere in all the workshops was friendly and felt like a safe space to learn new things. Every facilitator was professional and kind. However, the workshop titles were often unclear, making it difficult to choose among them; adding descriptions and objectives would have been very helpful. Additionally, knowing in advance about the post-workshop feedback request would have helped me make more informed decisions, as a full overview of pre, during, and post workshop requirements would be ideal. Overall, I had a fantastic and enjoyable four days and would highly recommend these workshops to anyone interested in learning various fun and engaging approaches to sustainability.

P2

Overall, the workshops were welcoming and supportive. The facilitators were professional and approachable, making each session enjoyable. Having clear descriptions and objectives for each workshop would help in making informed choices. Knowing about any post-workshop requirements in advance would also be useful. I highly recommend these workshops to anyone interested in art, sustainability, and community engagement.

P3

I decided to enroll in this workshop because the activities seemed interesting but also because I wanted to find out how those activities could enhance team building and collaboration. In a general perspective, I did enjoy the activities, they gave me ideas about the type of research and activities that are being carried out by the university. It also helped me socialize with other students and "break the ice" with them, finding that many of us had interests in common or at least allowed us to find different perspectives, feelings and interesting facts about other people. In the end, I understood how those crafting activities can be related and used for collaboration, and it opened my mind about the topic. I would like to talk a little about each of the workshops I participated in, so I'm listing them below, and all my feedback and comments can be used by TB-Gobra if needed.

P4

As a conclusion, I enjoyed these workshops and would love if this type of activities happened more often. I consider everyone should be able to have the feeling of being included and participating in an activity just as we all felt while being there. It was a truly great experience.

P5

To sum it up, I really enjoyed all the workshops I attended to. Prior to this I didn't know you could create so much using only naturally sourced and dyed materials. The colors of wool and felt looked very nice too, even maybe better than the synthetic dyed ones because of that bit less saturated tone. During the courses I also discovered few new hobbies to try by myself in the future, as well as spent my time well both with new people and these that I already knew.

P6

When I saw the sign-up for the workshop course, I was really interested and excited to participate and learn more about traditional Finnish crafting and sustainable crafting. As an avid crafter myself, I really enjoy working with my hands and spend a lot of my free time crafting or cooking, so from the get-go, the course looked promising. The only reservations I had was the lack of explanation on the signup sheet for what the workshop actually entailed, and a short description of each, I think, would have been helpful.

P7

Overall I think the module was really well run and a lot of fun, as well as being really interesting and insightful. I think quite a few of the activities would work well as cooperative team-building exercises, especially some of the more unusual ones like the cooking and embroidery ones. Some of the workshop instructions could have been a little more clear at times, and a little more information as to what I was signing up for would have been nice, but overall a worthwhile experience.

P8

Overall, the most memorable aspects of the workshops were the sense of community and the importance of sharing. Doing things with your hands opened up the conversation and lowered the threshold for meeting others. I felt that the workshops brought the participants to the edge of the essential, to that moment and in a certain way sensitized to sensing different signals from the environment than in everyday life.

P9

This four-day series of workshops was a great opportunity for me to connect with the culture of Finnish Lapland. Amid the more serious, academic courses of the first semester, these hands-on workshops and the discussions around food, which are so tied to everyday life, gave my brain a chance to rest. It was refreshing to chat with classmates and other participants in both indoor and outdoor Finnish-inspired spaces, or just listen quietly to their personal stories and ideas. This balance of work and rest, switching between indoor and outdoor activities, was exactly the kind of teaching approach I had imagined - and hoped for - in Finland. I really hope I get the chance to take part in more workshops like this in the future.

From the questionnaire

It would be better if activities combine lectures and practices, such as the lecture about sustainable food.

More defined objectives and outcomes. Also providing more background on certain topics before sessions.

This course has enhanced my creative thinking and deepened my commitment to sustainability, both personally and professionally. It improved my teamwork, project management, and problem-solving skills, while providing practical experience in sustainable design methods. These new abilities will help me contribute to eco-conscious solutions in my field.

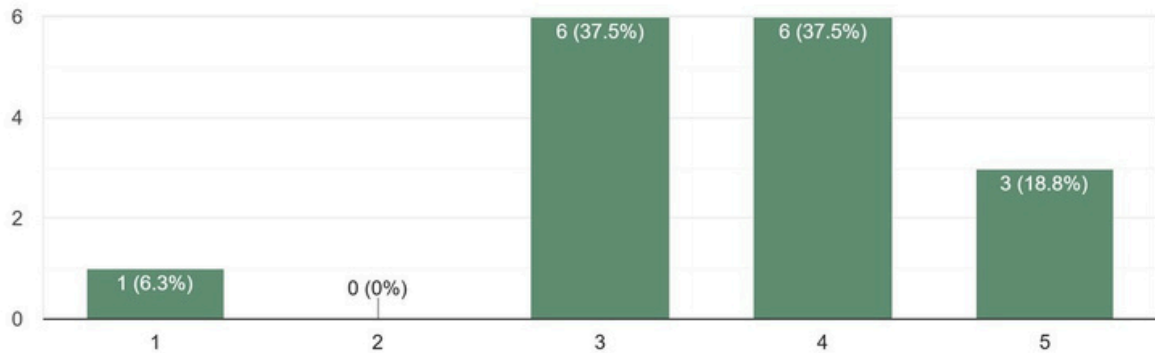
Participating in this workshop has greatly improved my personal and professional development. I've gained a deeper understanding of sustainable culinary practices and craft activities, such as making mandalas and working with wool, which have fostered more conscious food choices and a creative mindset. The focus on teamwork enhanced my collaboration and problem-solving skills, while insights into the green agri-food sector, including Fair Trade and ethical practices, will inform my future projects. Overall, the workshop has empowered me to contribute positively to sustainability in my community and workplace.



Green AgriFood Production

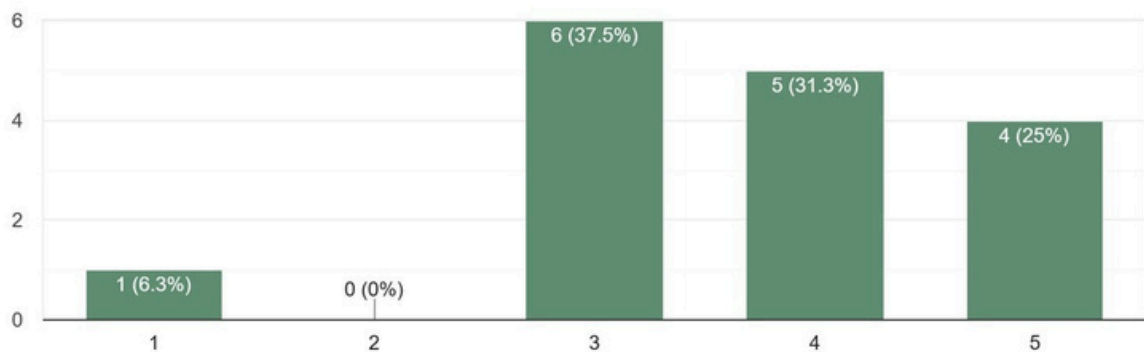
23. I am satisfied with the session about Agriculture

16 responses



25. The session about Agriculture was effective for teaching new competences

16 responses



CAPTION ON SCALE 1 (MINIMUM) - 5 (MAXIMUM), MOST OF THE PARTICIPANTS DID NOT FIND AGRI FOOD PRODUCTION TOO DIFFICULT

ECO-INNOVATION HACKATHON

The feedback on the Eco-Innovation Hackathon highlights its engaging and collaborative nature, with participants appreciating the focus on sustainability and innovation in agriculture. Many valued the opportunity to brainstorm solutions, exchange ideas with diverse teammates, and gain new perspectives on topics like biodiversity, waste management, and ecosystem health. The interactive format and approachable facilitation were well-received, fostering creativity and knowledge sharing.

However, some noted challenges, including a lack of prior knowledge on the topic, which made the outcomes feel superficial. Suggestions for improvement included providing a clearer structure, offering an introductory overview of the topic, and stronger facilitation to guide discussions effectively within the time constraints. Overall, the hackathon was seen as a valuable learning experience that sparked creativity and awareness rather than focusing solely on developing concrete solutions.

Activity Point Of Review

Eco-Innovation Hackathon

P1

It was great to have a quick challenge focused on eco and sustainability in agriculture. For me, it was the first time I explored what happens on agricultural lands, including topics like animals, waste, recycling, and the impact on the ecosystem. Working with a teammate who already had background knowledge was also helpful; he provided insights, and I contributed fresh perspectives based on what he explained. Lastly, the facilitator was friendly and approachable, so it didn't feel like a lecture.

P2

This was my first workshop session in this course, and it turned out to be the most inspiring and engaging in my opinion. We paired up to work on the sustainable innovation topic, and the collaborative process allowed me to discuss various aspects with my partner, which sparked and encouraged my creativity and made brainstorming sessions very enjoyable. I had a lot of fun looking at the topic from different perspectives and presenting our ideas to the class. Additionally, listening to others' presentations gave me even more new knowledge. It was wonderful to have the chance to share and exchange ideas with people from diverse backgrounds.

P3

Even if the Hackathons I've participated in before took longer than 2 hours, it was nice to brainstorm about innovation in Agriculture, specifically in Biodiversity enhancement and come up with potential solutions to solve the problem of low biodiversity that leads to ecosystem vulnerability. As most of the workshop participants were Service Design Master students and, in my case, I knew a little about the topic, I think we were prepared to come up with some immediate ideas and think of the different levels that a strategy has to have: in our case, we considered the individual, the local collaboration and the governmental levels. You might need to consider adapting it a little bit if the participants are not familiar with the topic – giving an introduction to the topic or presenting one topic as inspiration to the hackathon.

P4

Participating in the Eco-Innovation Hackathon was enlightening. Our team worked on effective practices to revitalize nutrient-degraded farmlands. Collaborating with people from different backgrounds pushed us to think creatively. The experience deepened my understanding of environmental issues in agriculture and the importance of innovative solutions.

P5

The hackathon focused on agricultural innovation. The topic itself was interesting, although, due to our lack of prior experience, our results felt somewhat superficial. The workshop lacked structure, and since a hackathon is a time-constrained event, more guidance and stronger facilitation would have been beneficial. Despite this, the group, consisting mostly of service design students with experience in organizing sprints and workshops, managed to navigate things smoothly. It was exciting to see how many of our ideas overlapped during the discussions and presentations, allowing for some interesting combinations. Overall, I believe this hackathon was more about engaging with the topic rather than creating concrete solutions.



BIODIVERSITY ROLE PLAY

The feedback on the biodiversity workshop highlights its creative and interactive approach, which effectively demonstrated the complexity of ecosystems and the interconnected roles of their elements. Participants appreciated the opportunity to take on diverse perspectives, explore environmental challenges, and engage in collaborative problem-solving, which deepened their understanding of biodiversity and farming systems. Suggestions for improvement included clearer communication of workshop objectives beforehand to attract a larger and more diverse group. Overall, the session was seen as an innovative and thought-provoking experience that fostered teamwork, leadership, and a greater appreciation of ecological systems. As one stated: “The level of teamwork involved really opened my eyes to how things are done and how to work alongside nature instead of trying to control it. I felt that I had to flex my leadership and team-playing skills during this particular course.”

AGRI-FOOD PRODUCTION JEOPARDY

The workshop focused on collaboration through interactive and hands-on activities, fostering teamwork and creative problem-solving. The Kahoot quiz on agricultural food production and CO2 emissions sparked discussions, though the low participation and simplicity of the session limited its depth. Participants appreciated the friendly atmosphere and small gestures, like gifts, which boosted morale.

Bio-Diversity Role-Play

P1

This interactive session creatively explored the concept of biodiversity, emphasizing the complexity of ecosystems and the crucial role each element plays. It was interesting to see how everyone fully embraced their roles and contributed additional information, helping the group recognize gaps in understanding. Much of this was influenced by their knowledge of farming systems. Mathmut did a great job facilitating the workshop.

P2

In this workshop, we were assigned roles as various elements of nature and tasked with solving environmental challenges. This was a novel and thought-provoking experience, as it required us to step into perspectives we wouldn't normally consider. The process of problem-solving without prior knowledge of the situation was engaging, as it encouraged us to approach the issues from multiple angles and openly share our ideas.

However, one challenge was the small number of participants, which limited the depth of the interactions and the scale of the final performance that was supposed to conclude the workshop. To enhance the effectiveness of this type of workshop, I suggest clearer communication of its objectives in advance. If potential participants knew more about the workshop's goals and format, it might attract a larger, more diverse group.

P3

Even if the Hackathons I've participated in before took longer than 2 hours, it was nice to brainstorm about innovation in Agriculture, specifically in Biodiversity enhancement and come up with potential solutions to solve the problem of low biodiversity that leads to ecosystem vulnerability. As most of the workshop participants were Service Design Master students and, in my case, I knew a little about the topic, I think we were prepared to come up with some immediate ideas and think of the different levels that a strategy has to have: in our case, we considered the individual, the local collaboration and the governmental levels. You might need to consider adapting it a little bit if the participants are not familiar with the topic – giving an introduction to the topic or presenting one topic as inspiration to the hackathon.

P4

This interactive session was interesting and had a creative approach to helping participants to understand the role of bio-diversity. This workshop demonstrated to me the complex nature of bio-diversity and the need for everything within the ecosystem. During the group activity, it became very clear how complex the bio-diversity system is and how everyone had a different opinion on how we could manage it depending on their understanding of the farming system.

P5

This was not at all what I had expected. The level of teamwork involved really opened my eyes to how things are done and how to work alongside nature instead of trying to control it. I felt that I had to flex my leadership and team-playing skills during this particular course.



Agri-Food Production Jeopardy

P1

This Kahoot was cool and I've discovered interesting facts about meat consumption in the EU and CO2 emissions. It was a pity that few people participated. Maybe with a higher participation, it can be even more fun. Loved the detail that there were gifts – it's a tiny detail, but it makes people feel happy

P2

The Agri-food production workshop was quite short and very simple. There were only four of us and the leader, and we played a quiz on the Kahoot platform related to agricultural food production. In addition, at the beginning we discussed why "team-building" is an important tool. Although the topics raised in Kahoot sparked discussion among the participants, I think Kahoot was perhaps not the best possible implementation. I did learn something new with the help of the quiz, but otherwise the workshop was quite short and poor in content. All the participants were again really nice and we had a good time, which was perhaps the strength of this workshop.

Since the workshop ended so early, we went to see the "bike felting" workshop. Based on the name, I had absolutely no idea what the workshop would contain. It was interesting to see and learn how raw wool is worked, and its "felting" using a wheel. Unfortunately, the developed method did not fully work, but with the help of failures, we thought together as a group on how to improve the method and solve the problems that came up. Working together was fun, even if the execution was perhaps not exactly what was planned. It was nice to notice how the participants were eager to participate in each work step, and without the group, the wool sheet would not have been completed.

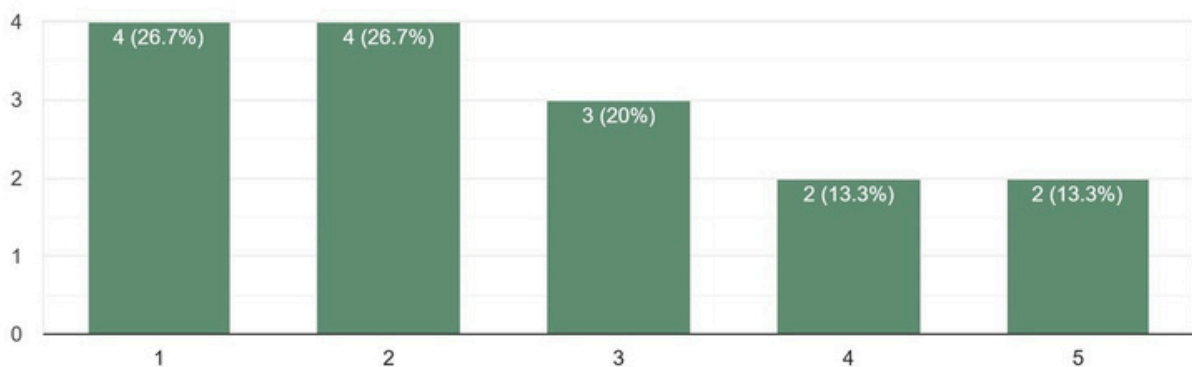


Sustainable Cooking



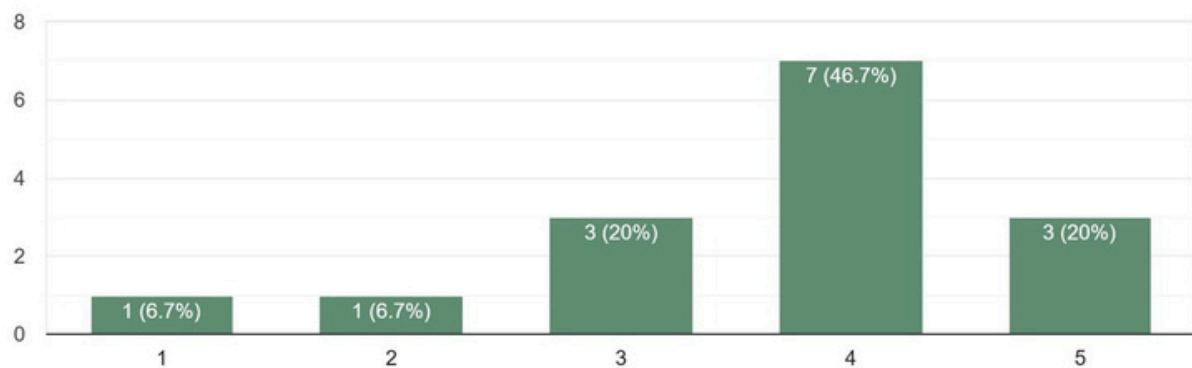
31. The session about Cooking was too difficult

15 responses



28. I am satisfied with the session about Cooking

15 responses



Caption: On scale 1 (minum) - 5 (maxim), most of the participants did not find cooking too difficult, anyhow some did find it too difficult

SUSTAINABLE MENU CREATION CHALLENGE

The workshop emphasized collaboration through its cooking challenge, which developed teamwork and problem-solving skills in a dynamic and resource-constrained environment. Participants were paired up, given basic and randomly assigned ingredients, and tasked with creating a meal while incorporating storytelling into their dish. This exercise required clear communication, trust-building, and creative thinking under time pressure, fostering mutual confidence and a sense of accomplishment among team members.

The competitive yet cooperative atmosphere encouraged participants to observe and learn from other teams' strategies, sparking creativity and camaraderie. While some found the theoretical portion less interactive, the cooking activity stood out as a practical and engaging way to strengthen collaboration and resourcefulness in a hands-on setting.



Activity Point Of Review

Sustainable Menu Creation challenge

P1

The facilitators were very professional and engaging, encouraging questions and giving everyone time to participate. I learned a lot about human behavior, especially around food choices and decision-making, and the section on neuroscience and how the brain works was particularly interesting. However, the session felt more theoretical than I expected. I had anticipated a practical focus, and it wasn't clearly communicated that it would be split into two parts, with one being theoretical.

P2

I attended this workshop in the morning, which was mainly about presentations by the facilitators. They walked us through topics related to their organisation, consumer behaviour around food consumption, food security, and solutions for creating sustainable menus. I found the focus on human behaviour and perspectives toward food consumption especially interesting, as it aligns with my interest in human-centred service design. The presentation emphasised on how people make food choices today, what affected their decision making, these insights were so valuable for me as a service designer to investigate users needs. However, the workshop lacked interactive activities; we were passive listeners for 2-3 hours, which made the session less engaging from a learning perspective, even though the content itself was really beneficial.

P3

I liked the longer introduction to the topic in the morning, but it was a pity I couldn't participate in creating the menu itself in the afternoon – I would turn these two workshops into one and make sure that people could attend both parts. The neuroscience and psychological parts were surprisingly interesting and it's very important to promote these topics to create sustainable menus – hopefully, people will take inspiration from the workshop and will apply the shared knowledge! We had great discussions during the presentation too – how is it possible that sometimes we understand zero to very little of the ingredients that are written in the packages of the food products that we buy in the supermarket? It's literally "food for thought"! It was nice to meet other TB-GOBRA partners and have an official introduction to their work outside of the project itself.

P4

This session was primarily a presentation, so it was a bit less interactive than the other workshops, but it was packed with useful insights. The focus was on sustainable sourcing, seasonal ingredients, and reducing waste, which offered a lot of valuable information about building a responsible menu. While it wasn't the most engaging format, the content was eye-opening, and it was interesting to see the different generations' eating and menu creation habits, as older generations for example used more offal, and it got me thinking about sustainability from a fresh perspective.

P5

In this session, we were again divided into pairs and received a set of basic ingredients, along with additional items drawn by lot. The challenge was to create a meal using these limited resources, while also incorporating storytelling into the dish. This competitive aspect added an exciting layer to the experience, and I'm proud to say that our team won first place. It was a rewarding exercise in resourcefulness - turning a small selection of ingredients into something creative and flavourful. Working with my classmate, whom I knew before but had never cooked with, helped strengthen our trust and collaboration. We realised how well we could work together under pressure, which increased our mutual confidence.

P6

Participating in this workshop was fun, it was like participating in a tv contest. Getting creative with food is something that I enjoy in general, but the extra difficulty of not being able to choose the products made it harder although fun. I had a lot of laughs, and I felt like I was forced to really think and make clever use of all the ingredients. It was also interesting to look around and see other teams talking, agreeing on how to work together and developing an interesting dish. The only downside that I found was that it would have been nice to be able to try everyone else's dishes and share our own not only with the judges but also with the other team members.

P7

Even though I never made an actual menu, I found the first part of the workshop very interesting. Learning about which aspects have the most impact on our decision making when grocery shopping and overall food consumption and what kind of neuroscience have been made concerning that topic, really opened my eyes. How can it be, we prefer unhealthy and unsustainable food over both healthy and sustainable one just because of appearance and taste? Even though it was an interesting topic, it would have been nice to have more exchange and interaction between us participants. I had a lot of thoughts and ideas concerning this topic myself, but never had a chance to share them. Again, there was not enough time.

P8

The psychological and neuroscience perspective on taste and visual perception, linked to influencing sustainable behavior, was fascinating. It provided a solid foundation for exploring the topic of sustainable menu creation. Unfortunately, it wasn't communicated that the workshop was split into two parts, so I missed the second part, which involved actual cooking. Despite that, I felt confident in applying the knowledge to the topic of menu creation. It's amazing how visual cues and reward systems can nudge people towards certain behaviors, and I would have loved to experiment with different menu designs and their impacts.

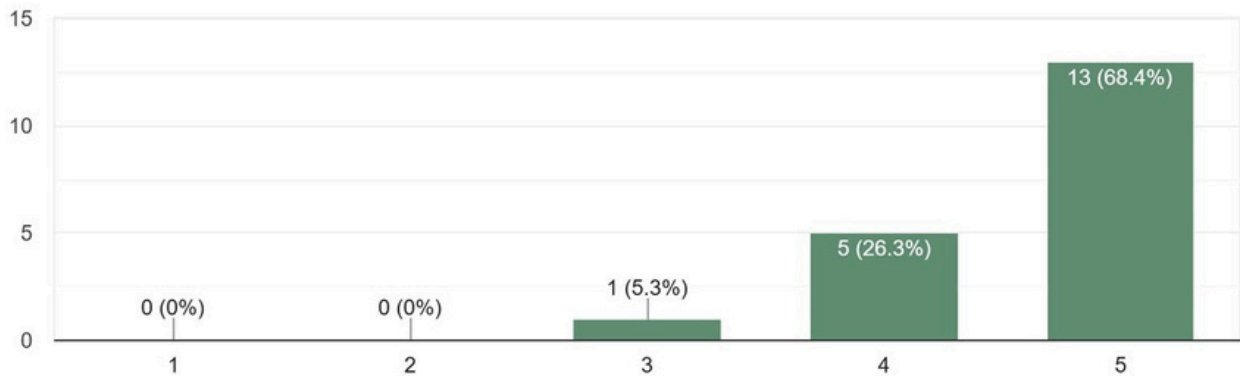
P9

This workshop was a presentation by teams from Italy and Germany, based on an EU report about food consumption. Throughout the presentation, there were various small discussions sparked by different questions. It made me realize that some food consumption patterns in modern Chinese society are also widespread across EU countries. For instance, many food packages in supermarkets come with long lists of complex ingredients that few people actually understand. One part of the report, which focused on how to improve the menu-reading experience, reminded me of the unique ways restaurants back in my hometown present their menus. From traditional text menus, to walls full of food pictures illuminated in lightboxes, and even 3D models of the dishes - all of which help customers make their choices. However, the question of how to make this system more sustainable left me deep in thought. I think when I visit home again, I'll see our menu system from a whole new perspective.

Sustainable Craft

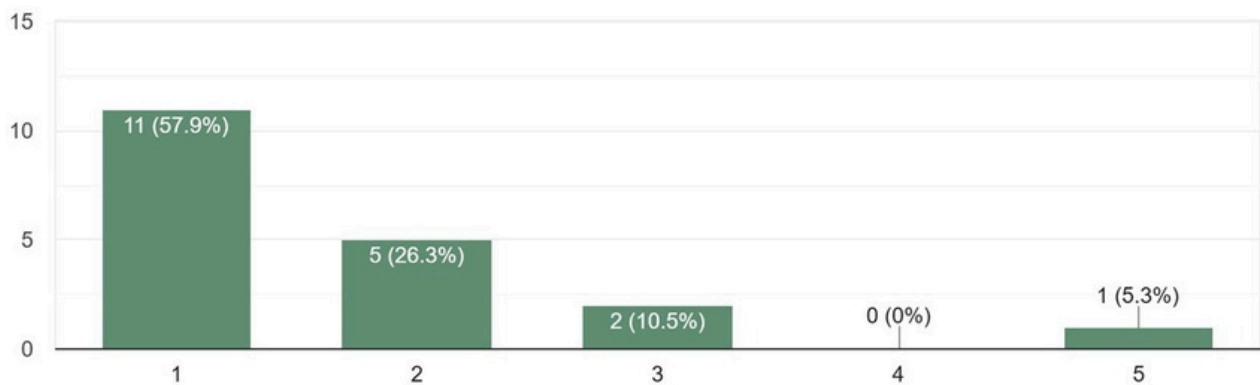
18. I am satisfied with the session about Crafts

19 responses



21. The session about Crafts was too difficult

19 responses



Caption: On scale 1 (minum) - 5 (maxim), most of the participants did not find Crafting too difficult, anyhow some did find it too difficult

General

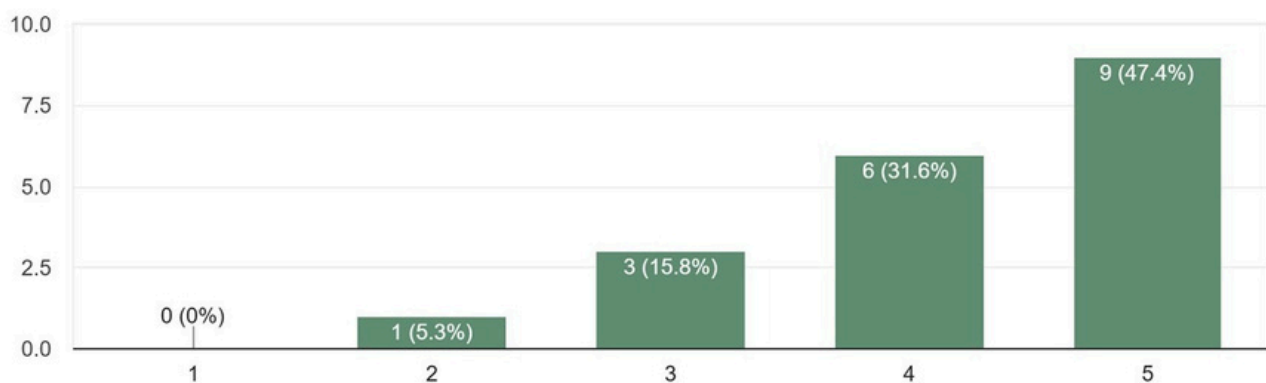
There should have been more teamwork. For example when crafting, everybody did their own thing. There was not enough interaction with others. No brainstorming or working together. Also too little time. Maybe less courses but more time for one exercise.

It would be good to have more information at the end of the craft workshop about how we could use this in our wider context



22. I appreciated the teaching approach adopted in the session about Crafts

19 responses



BIKE FELTING

The feedback on the Bike Felting workshop highlights its collaborative and hands-on nature, fostering a sense of community and teamwork among participants. Many appreciated the opportunity to learn about the felting process using organic materials, emphasizing sustainability and traditional techniques. The outdoor setting and group dynamics were appreciated for their engaging and refreshing atmosphere, sparking conversations and connections between participants from diverse backgrounds.

However, some suggested improvements included providing clearer workshop descriptions to set expectations and ensuring more balanced participation to keep everyone actively involved. A few participants noted challenges, such as waiting periods and unclear roles, which could be addressed by dividing tasks or forming smaller groups. Despite minor issues, the workshop was widely regarded as enjoyable, educational, and impactful, blending creativity, tradition, and collaboration effectively.

Activity Point Of Review

Bike Felting

P1

This was a completely new topic for me; I had never read, heard, or seen anything about it before. While I knew about using animal wool, like sheep's wool, for clothing and textiles, actually watching and taking part in the process was really interesting. Seeing the team collaborate to complete the task within the time frame was inspiring, and being around like-minded people brought positivity and self-assurance. Once again, I learned how simple yet essential reusing and recycling can be for sustainability. My only suggestion would be that the workshop title didn't clearly reflect the content; a brief description and objectives for each title would be helpful.

P2

The bike felting session was both fun and collaborative. We worked outdoors throughout the workshop, helping each other with various tasks, for example preparing the wool, layering the wool. It was exciting to try out new crafting practices I'd never done before. Starting from raw wool and turning it into something functional made the process feel special, as we got to experience each step come together right from scratch, which made me really appreciate the handcraft itself. Moreover, the workshop encouraged a lot of interaction between participants, we relied on each other to get things done. It provided me such a strong sense of community and more joy to collaborate that can make a project better.

P3

It was nice to work outdoors and take a more collaborative approach to crafting. This workshop required everyone to work together to create a wool blanket. The open, engaging atmosphere encouraged contributions to various tasks, sparking conversations about both the felting technique and the participants' diverse backgrounds. I also enjoyed the moments of having coffee and chatting with the team outside.

P4

Working outdoors and taking a collaborative approach to crafting was refreshing. This workshop brought everyone together to create a wool blanket, with each person contributing to different tasks in an open, lively setting. The atmosphere encouraged discussions—not just about felting techniques but also about our unique backgrounds and experiences, as most of us were international students. I especially enjoyed the wool selection and the casual chats with the team, which added to the whole experience.

P5

The demonstration of this technique was really engaging and seeing the whole process of creating a wool blanket was fun. This workshop stood out as having the most team collaboration to create the final outcome while the other workshops had more individual outcomes. I enjoyed the atmosphere of this workshop and the openness of everyone to contribute to the different tasks. While completing the task you were able to engage with other participants and discuss the technique we were learning about but also learn more about the different participants and their background.

P6

Working outdoors on the bike felting project was refreshing. I was involved in rolling the wool, and seeing it transform into a felt piece was engaging. The collaborative atmosphere encouraged us to share stories and learn from each other. Using natural materials highlighted the simplicity and importance of sustainability in a hands-on way.

P7

This workshop, I would say, was my favorite of all the ones I took part in. Before this activity, I had zero knowledge of how wool is processed and used. I had never seen wool directly from a farm nor touched it. For me, this whole process was about learning and getting hands on it. I was excited to take part in every single part of the process. At the same time, it was fun and I got to work together with many other participants. I remember the moment when we all finally attached the blanket to the bike and as soon as the guy on the bike began rolling it, we could feel the unity of the whole group happily showing their emotion by clapping or screaming. Also, the way everyone tried to find a solution when the rope broke the first time and how we all together tried to make it work and succeeded in the end was something special. I would really enjoy having more chances to be part of a group like that.

P9

I'm so happy that I got to see firsthand how felt is made from wool. What shocked me was how simple the concept is and how easy it is to make. I'm looking forward to making my own in my free time.

P10

Bike Felting was the fourth workshop that I participated in, and though still interesting, I think it ended up being my least favourite. Because there had been no description in the sign up form I had no idea what the activity was going to be, and was definitely not what I had expected. Although I enjoyed chatting with people and working together to make a single blanket, it got tedious as the only activity I got to do was pulling the wool. I think if there had been less people or smaller teams working on multiple blankets it would have been more fun, but as it was there was a lot of time where I wasn't doing anything and got really cold standing around.

P11

The Bike Felting workshop was a physical joint effort and even though the end result didn't quite go as planned, the joy of doing it and learning new things together put a smile on our faces. The workshop's versatile work phases before and after felting kept interest alive.

P12

This workshop was a surprise, as I initially thought we would be felting an actual bike, similar to the Mushroom workshop. However, I thoroughly enjoyed the process of creating a wool blanket and learning the different creative techniques involved. Being outside and crafting together fostered a strong sense of community and teamwork. I believe this format is excellent for bringing people together and introducing them to traditional craft techniques while promoting collaboration and a shared sense of accomplishment. It was a lot of fun!

This was the most collaborative and knowledge-driven workshop of the series and a great example of one of the core themes of the Sustainable Art and Design master's program: how to revive traditional local cultures using art-based and community-based participatory approaches. In the context of Finnish Lapland, this means how to preserve and revitalize Sámi culture. Cultural development and preservation aren't isolated or static processes. As environments evolve, cultural transmission also adapts to these changes, and most cultures gradually blend with others through contact. Wool has played an important role in human history. It was a crucial material for nomadic people, used for building shelters and clothing, especially in cold, damp regions, and has also been widely used in creating decorative items. For modern crafts, wool felt can be both the raw material for artistic creation and the final product. I've made felt art using industrially dyed wool before, but I wasn't interested in where the material came from and didn't realize that sustainability in art starts with material choices. In this workshop, I worked with organic wool from local farms, which still had bits of dust and leaves mixed in. We split into groups and had different roles: first, we fluffed the wool, then layered and wet it with warm water mixed with pine resin. We wrapped and rolled it on a cylindrical tool, then tied it tight. Finally, in a nod to traditional Sámi methods, we attached the wool to a bike, and the pressure created by cycling over the ground helped turn it into felt.

Although some technical details prevented the Bike-Felting process from fully working, the whole experience was incredibly engaging and a really effective way to pass down traditional craft knowledge.



HIMMELI CRAFT

The Himmeli Craft workshop emphasised collaboration, cultural appreciation, and creative problem-solving. Participants, ranging from beginners to experienced crafters, worked individually or in pairs to create intricate Himmeli designs using natural and sustainable materials.

Many participants collaborated to create larger structures or assist each other with challenging steps, which fostered teamwork and mutual support. The process of holding, threading, and aligning materials often required dual efforts, making teamwork essential.

The workshop included discussions about the Finnish origins of Himmeli and its similarities with crafts like Polish "Pająk" or German ornaments.

Participants shared cultural connections, enhancing their understanding of shared traditions. Conversations during crafting allowed participants to bond over shared challenges and successes, enhancing the group's cohesion and fostering a sense of community.

While the facilitator provided patterns, participants had the freedom to explore and personalize their designs, encouraging creativity and experimentation. The activity required patience, attention to detail, and dexterity, challenging participants while offering a rewarding sense of accomplishment.

Overall, the workshop blended traditional craft techniques with a focus on teamwork, cultural exploration, and creative expression, leaving participants inspired and fulfilled.



Himmeli Craft

P1

The main takeaway from the Himmeli workshop was once again the importance of reusing, recycling, and sustainability. Seeing natural materials used in arts and crafts and various designs was truly inspiring. I don't remember working on a hands-on craft since I became an adult, so it was both challenging and fun to participate in this workshop. The facilitator was friendly and helpful, and collaborating strategically with my teammate to build a Himmeli together demonstrated great communication, alignment, and teamwork.

P2

Before joining this workshop, I had no idea what Himmeli was. But it turned out to be one of my favourite workshops in the course. This activity allowed me to learn by doing, and the process required close attention to detail, which helped me stay focused and made the experience really meaningful. One thing I loved was finding your own way in crafting— there were no strict rules. The facilitator showed us some example patterns, but as we worked, I experimented and discovered a few new patterns myself. This creative freedom made the workshop feel more personalised as I could explore and develop my own style in making the Himmeli.

P3

It was so cool to learn about Finnish Arts and Crafts with Maria! I met new people apart from my SDSI colleagues and, as doing Himmeli requires some time and patience, I was surprised that people really took the time to help each other out. I point here the importance of leaving the screens out and doing something with our hands: It felt great that it was not another PPT or screen-based activity. Even if this activity required focus, it felt great that we were doing it together – the collaborative aspect was impressive and then the joy to see the Himmeli piece finally ready! It was great to use sustainable materials and keep the workshop himmeli instructions – I inspired some family members and they created their himmeli at home in Portugal too

P4

This was a fun, hands-on session! The activity brought everyone together, blending skill levels from experienced crafters to beginners like me, making it enjoyable for all. Some people showcased impressive craftsmanship, which was inspiring to see, but the design was accessible enough for those of us just learning the technique for the first time.

P5

Creating the pyramid-shaped Himmelli was both challenging and rewarding. Working with natural materials required patience, but I'm proud to have it hanging in my bedroom now. The facilitator was supportive, and learning alongside others made the experience enjoyable. It showed me the beauty of simple materials and traditional crafting techniques.

P6

On the same day, we also had "Himmeli craft" which was a traditional Finnish craft I also was excited to try. Before going to this workshop, I talked with my parents who showed me that this art form is very similar to Polish "Pająk" (meaning spider), which also has been traditionally made as a Christmas ornament in my home country. Making this form required a lot of focus and patience, especially if you used fragile dried straw instead of the plastic or paper straws. The hard work although really paid off, himmeli looked very nicely, even if you made one of the simpler forms. You could also experiment with different lengths of straws, which also raised creativity and made you think of different, not so traditional solutions.

P7

In this workshop we crafted Himmelis. This time, we had more time for crafting, which was very much needed. Thinking about team building and creative work, the workshop would have needed more structure to get the participants into working in a team. I thought, for example, that everybody could have made one piece of one big Himmeli. Somehow, with a lot of creativity, we would have managed to get all the small crafts together into one big Himmeli. It would have forced us to talk and work together and create solutions. All in all, I did enjoy crafting my first ever Himmeli and I see a lot of potential in the idea of developing team building with focus on a more sustainable future.

P8

This was a bit more challenging than I had expected, but I enjoy a challenge. It was something new to learn, and I appreciated understanding the cultural significance of Himmeli craft.

P9

After lunch, the Himmeli workshop began. Although himmel are a Finnish decoration, I had never made any kind of himmel myself. So I started practicing with cardboard whistles, from which I moved on to a thin reed. Working required patience, precision and concentration, but was still very addictive and relaxing in its own way. Together with another participant, we also made a joint bigger himmel out of water reeds. It took two people to make a big himmel, because it was much easier when the other one supported or held the himmel so that it didn't move. The material was fine fragile, so could not rush. It was also nice to take a break from time to time, because you often had to hold your breath while threading the thread through the thin reeds. The wonderful thing about the Himmels was that you can easily connect individual Himmels to each other. Many of the participants either connected their own individual channels to each other or had another person make part of a larger Himmel triangle, and when they were combined, a whole triangle was formed. Thus, the creations of this workshop were in their own ways joint works, and each one showed the different handprints of its creators. Helping others and giving advice is also an important part of team building. In the same way as in the Mandala workshop, it was wonderful to help and get help if you didn't know something. I myself stayed to help with the end of another pair of himmel, and we thought together how it should be worked on.

P10

Himmeli Craft was the last workshop I did (I would've done more but was off ill Sunday), and it proved to be joint favourite with the blanket embroidery. I enjoyed learning about how the reeds have to be soaked to be used and how families would make these decorations every year for Christmas. These decorations are very similar in style to some of the traditional German ornaments as they both use natural materials and red thread, so I was definitely inspired to have a go at making these back home for Christmas to decorate my own house. I appreciated how, in the workshop, there was the ability to follow the instructions of an example version or just have a go at experimenting and creating your own. The availability of a range of materials to use for the straws was also really clever and made the workshop much more approachable and accessible for everyone.

P11

The workshop was beginner friendly and relaxing like all the other craft workshops. We started with an introduction about the Himmeli craft and the history of it and traditional methods of doing it and some displays of the artworks made with the straws used to make Himmeli. Then we were all given choices to work on it with either the natural straws or the colorful paper ones.

It was good to work on the basic structure and then add to it by adding more designs. All the while everyone was just talking and discussing random things, things about their culture, way of living, etc. It was a fun workshop. Some people were also working in pairs to make some mobiles together.

Then we had a little presentation about what we had made and we got to take our mobile home. It was a great experience learning something new and especially because I can apply it henceforth in other interactive artworks I plan to make.

P12

The Himmeli Craft workshop was challenging in a positive way and produced incredibly cool three-dimensional results. The workshop required concentration. I think it was good that the himmels were built in pairs, because as a group work it would have been quite chaotic and I feel I would have been overworked and my concentration would not have been so good.

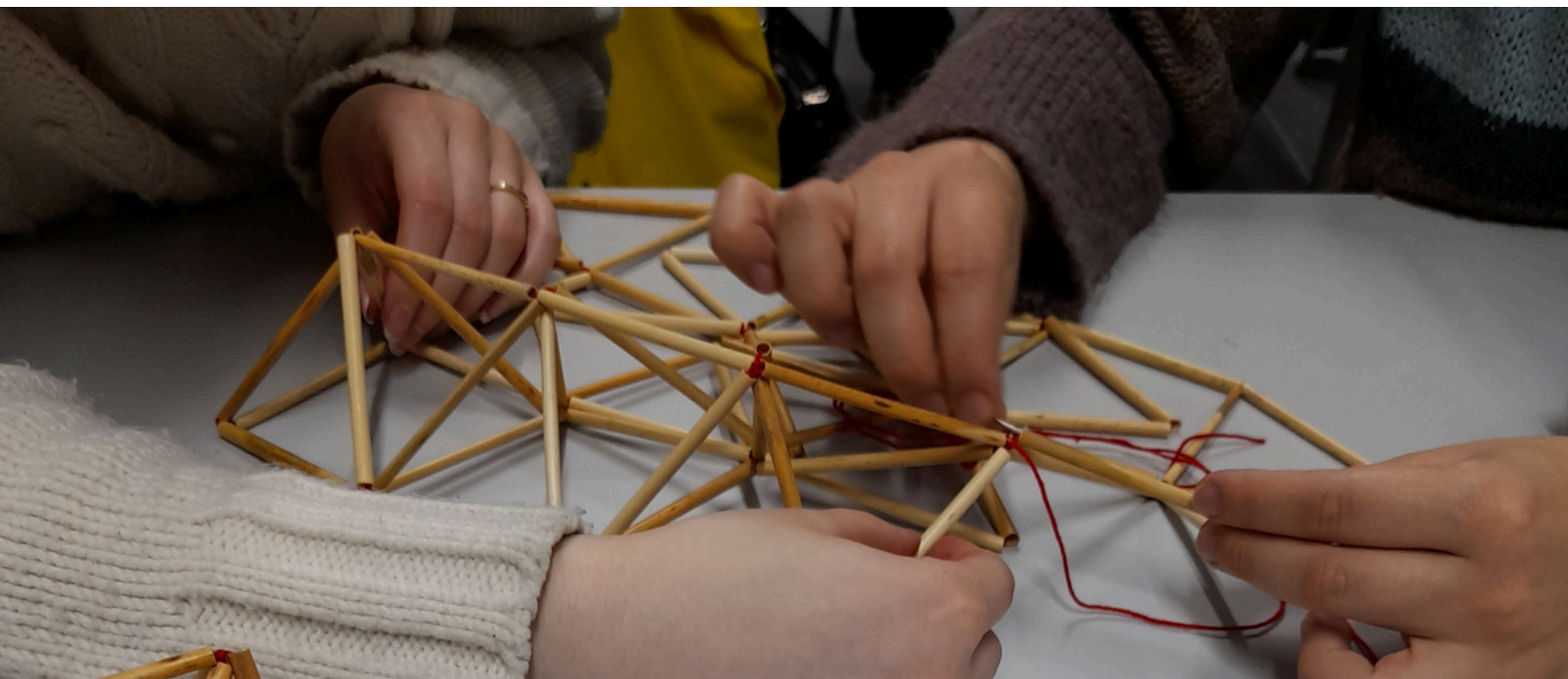
P12

This craft workshop started off as a bit of a struggle for me, but by the end, I felt a deep sense of fulfilment. At first, I was in awe of the scale and visual impact of the art pieces created by the instructor, Maria, using this technique. But at the same time, I underestimated it, thinking it was just a repetitive process of building and combining small modules, which didn't seem too difficult.

Even during Maria's demonstration, I didn't realize the challenge ahead. It wasn't until I picked my materials and started putting together my first basic module that I realized there's a certain way of thinking required that I hadn't grasped yet.

Watching other participants, whether working alone or in teams, build their modules made me anxious, and I started to feel a bit insecure. As a typical Chinese student, I was too shy to ask the teacher for help. Thankfully, I asked my classmate Shwetz for an explanation, and, like a slow turtle, I gradually got into the flow, focusing on constructing something whose shape was still unclear to me. Along the way, I received some encouraging feedback from classmates, which boosted my confidence and helped me finish the project. It also made me realize that my sense of aesthetics could gradually emerge through crafting.

I still don't know much about Himmeli or the natural materials used in it, but now when I go for a run by the lake, I pay more attention to the reed-like plants along the shore. I also learned from a Polish classmate said that this traditional craft is part of Polish culture too. Our conversation reaffirmed the idea that cultural forms aren't exclusive to one place.



WOVEN MANDALA

The Woven Mandala workshop, inspired by a traditional Mexican craft, was widely appreciated for its engaging, collaborative, and beginner-friendly nature. Participants learned to weave mandalas using colorful yarns on wooden sticks, with a focus on teamwork and cultural exchange. The workshop fostered creativity and bonding as individuals worked together to select colors and designs, often switching projects to create pieces that reflected group collaboration.

Facilitator enriched the experience by sharing the cultural and symbolic background of mandalas, highlighting their cross-cultural significance and the meanings of different colors. The activity provided a safe, relaxed environment for participants to connect, share ideas, and learn from one another, encouraging communication and breaking down cultural and social barriers.

The final creations were a mix of individual expression and collective effort, with some participants displaying their mandalas together as a collaborative art piece. Many valued the workshop for its clear instructions, the freedom to explore creativity, and the opportunity to try a new craft, often sparking interest in continuing similar activities at home.



Woven Mandala

P1

I really enjoyed Lola's presentation, where she shared the cultural background of this technique from her hometown in Mexico. She also highlighted how mandalas are a universal symbol across many cultures. The workshop was both fun and easy to learn, and it encouraged teamwork as participants not only helped each other with the crafting technique but also collaborated on color choices, contributing to a co-design experience.

P2

This workshop introduced us to a traditional Mexican craft using yarn on wood sticks to create mandalas. Although I had participated in a similar workshop before, this time it was more collaborative, as we were instructed to work in pairs. For each layer we wove, one person chose a color, and the other selected the next. This created a piece that was both visually and symbolically the product of cooperation. Trusting each other's decisions and sharing our creative preferences allowed us to bond and step outside our comfort zones. It fostered an environment of open communication, where we could comfortably share and merge ideas.

P3

This craft workshop was really fun and easy to learn. I enjoyed the presentation at the start of the workshop to give more context to the craft and where it comes. This workshop also provoked team work as team members helped one another not only in the actual method of the craft but also in the selection of the colours contributing to a co-design approach. This workshop was also good because everyone had a mandala at the end of the workshop which they could display and discuss with other participants.

P4

The woven mandala workshop was a highlight. Learning the weaving techniques and understanding the symbolism behind mandalas added depth to the activity. The facilitator's clear instructions made it easy to follow, and choosing colors and patterns allowed for personal expression. Sharing our finished mandalas fostered a sense of community among us.

P5

This one, especially for me, was interesting because it was linked to my own culture and country. I have always enjoyed working with crafts, this one was an easy one to do but it had an interesting background. I had the chance to talk to my teammate as well and learn from her about life in Finland as someone from a different country. Also got to help her understand the process and supported her. Even after the workshop, I was still excited to continue so I brought some materials home to finish a second one. I do enjoy the interaction that all these crafting activities provide and the safe environment to make even introverts come out of their comfort zone, since it doesn't really feel invasive. I think activities like this can help people who struggle with socializing.

P5

My second workshop was "Woven mandala", this one was more relaxing, as we got explained how to do the main thing. I enjoyed being presented with crafts from different cultures like this one, and for example, himmeli that I did later. I really liked the part when we put together our mandalas into one big piece of art. It was nice to see how our collaboration can make something greater from this small craft.

P7

The workshop introduced a form of handicraft originally from Mexico, where different colored threads are wrapped around crossed thin sticks/sticks. The end result looks like a flag, and it can be attached to hang or combined with others of the same kind, creating a whole. Traditionally, the yarns are dyed using traditional Mexican methods from dyes made with natural raw materials.

We worked in groups of three, and the idea was to switch with your group members after each thread/color round. In this way, each cross/flag would become a work created together by the group. I had not participated in previous workshops and had not met other participants before, so I was a little nervous. But after sitting down with the other participants, speaking came naturally. All the workshop participants were really nice, and the workshop had a very nice and safe atmosphere. I thought it was very interesting that the host Lola had also gathered a handiwork background and shared, for example, the meanings of different colors in Mexican culture. With the help of color theories, we composed what kind of thread combinations we wanted for each cross. Lola also mentioned how "woven mandala" is also a cross-cultural craft, because it is used a lot in other cultures as well. I think this summed up the creations of the workshop very well, because all the participants came from different backgrounds, cultures and countries, but in this workshop we worked together and created something common. My group member was very excited because he has never done this kind of craft. We talked about how the so-called soft crafts have been stereotypically and binary considered suitable only for women, but how should everyone practice the craft they want. Such a workshop was therefore an opportunity for him to try handicrafts, and thus possibly find a new hobby.

P8

This, too, was a lot of fun, and really interesting to learn about the context and history behind the craft. The instructions on how to do the specific technique, I think, were clearer in this workshop than in the embroidery one, which definitely helped more people get the hang of it. It was lovely to work again with the handmade yarn, and I found it particularly interesting to learn about how different colours were often used to symbolise different things, like yellow meaning wisdom, green love, and my particular favourite, orange meaning happiness and creativity. It was also nice that we got to take them home. Though I understand that we were meant to be switching the mandalas between us as a team-building exercise, most of us just wanted to work on our own as this seemed a lot more fun to be able to execute the unique ideas we had for colour schemes etc.

P9

This too was a beginner friendly workshop and we were divided into groups of three. And then people started the mandala with their own ideas and then we had to switch the mandal between the group and the next person did the continuation of the mandala. There was input, colors and design related, there were new ideas and also there was natural talk within the group about different things. In the end we could take the mandala or let it be with the workshop for display. So it was a good time bonding with strangers once again, in a relaxing way where I did not feel pressured to make friends, or present a wonderful creation. There was enough space to make mistakes and just go with the flow.

P10

The Woven Mandala workshop took place in a small classroom and after the leader's introduction, we started making Tsikuri. Everyone started their own Tsikuri, which was recycled in the group and different layers were created depending on the creator. We helped each other and those who had no experience in spinning wool felt a sense of success (plus happy picture messages to the family) and those who gave advice felt meaningful.

WOOL EMBROIDERY

The Wool Embroidery workshop was appreciated for its warm, collaborative atmosphere and its focus on personal and meaningful expression. Participants were paired to discuss their backgrounds and topics for embroidery, fostering conversations and breaking down barriers. Themes such as identity and cultural traditions often overlapped, creating connections and shared understanding among participants.

The workshop encouraged self-reflection and bonding, as partners worked together to translate personal narratives into embroidery. Many valued the opportunity to learn about others' perspectives while engaging in a hands-on, creative activity. However, some participants suggested that providing basic embroidery instructions and additional time for discussions before starting the activity would enhance the experience.

Despite varying levels of experience, participants found the activity enjoyable and stress-free, often appreciating the imperfections in their work as part of the creative process. The small group setting and personal storytelling fostered a sense of community, while the themes sparked meaningful exchanges about values and shared experiences. Many left inspired to continue exploring embroidery and crafting in their own time.



Wool Embroidery

P1

This workshop was well-organized with a wonderful atmosphere. A key aspect was the personal connection participants had to the embroidery theme, as each person chose a topic that was meaningful to them. This led to self-reflection and insightful conversations with partners. Coming from Peru, I felt a deep connection to wool, as our textiles are renowned, and the quality of alpaca wool is exceptional.

P2

In this session, we were paired off and started by introducing ourselves, discussing our backgrounds, and explaining what brought us to the workshop, how much experience we have with embroidery. This was a great way to break the ice, setting a warm, collaborative tone for the activity. Each of us embroidered a design on a small black fabric piece inspired by a topic we wanted to discuss. For me, it was mental health, how one can reach out for help and what kind of barriers he/she must overcome. My partner had the theme of identity a reflection on her journey as an immigrant looking for a sense of belonging and new roots. Both of our pieces had roots, engagement, healthy connections as common topics.

P3

In this workshop, we were paired in groups of two and began by introducing ourselves, discussing our backgrounds, and sharing why we were here. It was a great icebreaker, and this personal exchange set the tone for a more meaningful collaboration. The activity itself involved each of us embroidering a pattern onto a small piece of fabric, based on a topic we wanted to talk about. For me, it was the theme of identity—something I've been reflecting on lately as an immigrant searching for a sense of belonging and roots. My partner, on the other hand, chose to focus on seeking help in the modern era, specifically addressing the challenges of contemporary life. What was fascinating was the commonality that emerged between our works. While I embroidered patterns representing my search for roots, my partner expressed the need to reach out and ask for help. Despite different themes, our work reflected a shared human need for connection and stability. The collaborative aspect of this workshop was especially valuable, as working in pairs allowed us to merge our perspectives and support each other creatively. To improve this, it would be beneficial to allow more time for discussion before starting the embroidery, as it could deepen the conceptual foundation of the patterns we create.

P4

The first workshop I participated in was the wool embroidery workshop. As a workshop, this was well facilitated and had a great atmosphere. A key strength of this workshop was the fact that your embroidery topic needed to be a topic that was related to something important to you. This approach provoked internal reflection as well as simulating conversation with your partner. My topic for the embroidery was "How could Ireland maintain its rich history of folklore and myths". It was an interesting exercise to understand how this could be communicated through the activity of embroidery and what exactly Irish folklore was to me. The activity also provoked an interesting conversation with my partner who was focused on creating an embroidery piece around mental health. One area of improvement for the workshop would be the introduction of the method for embroidery at the start of the workshop for those of us who have not done embroidery before.

P5

This was the first workshop I took; I was not sure of what to expect, but when I entered the room, I felt very welcomed even by the people who I haven't met before.

I was even received with coffee, tea and cookies, something that I could have never imagined happening in my country so even that detail was already making me feel comfortable. The activity we made helped me understand the things that were important for people that, before entering that room and finishing the activity, were total strangers. In my case, I had the chance to learn about Irish folklore thanks to my teammate, and I learned that this topic had certain relevance for her. With little things like this, we can start to know somebody's soul in a certain way, and I believe that was something that couldn't have been achieved so quickly if we hadn't been doing this activity.

P6

On the first day I participated in the workshop Wool Embroidery, as I love to craft in my free time as well. We were instructed to think of a topic which interested us and partner up with somebody to talk about our topics. Afterwards we started embroidering our thoughts in a somewhat abstract way on the given pieces of fabric. I thought it too be a lovely idea, but I would have preferred to have more time. Also, I would have needed more instructions on the different techniques.

P7

What I enjoyed most about this course was the amount of bonding time with the other students. We were opening up to each other a lot, and we quickly became close friends. It surprised me, honestly, and I surprised myself too. It wasn't what I expected. The activity, while challenging, was easy enough to engage in casual conversation, and the topics of discussion were really interesting. My one wish is that we could have had more time to focus on finishing our little art pieces to take home.

P8

The first workshop I participated in was the Wool Embroidery workshop. Not knowing what to expect going in, the activity turned out to be a lot different that I had anticipated. However I really enjoyed learning about the topic, and was fascinated with both the traditional and modern takes on the craft. I learnt that blanket embroidery was traditionally done with wool that was made and dyed by hand, then used in winter to embroider the actual wool blankets. This definitely inspired me to want to have a go at hand dying yarn or fabric when I get back home because it sounds like a lot of fun, and I would love the experimentation side of it. I was also really interested to learn that women in a family would work on embroidering a blanket for a new bride to take with her, particularly as in my culture there are similar traditions, and as an engaged person I found it fascinating. I definitely plan to have another go at embroidering a blanket in the future. As far as the workshop itself, I really enjoyed doing the embroidery, but as someone who already had experience in embroidery, I think it was a lot more difficult for those who had never picked up a needle before. It would have been nice if there had been some instructions on how to do specific stitches.

P9

The workshop in itself felt great once I got there and then we did the craft piece and it ended. To start with, when I had read about the workshop I thought maybe it would be difficult as I had never done embroidery with wool before. I have some experience in basic needle work, and enjoyed stitching with beads etc on my own old clothes – thanks to the basic needle work workshop we had in primary school where we were supposed to design an apron for our mothers.

So, remembering that I was confident about my skills, but not really as much when I thought it out as I had forgotten a lot of stitches.

We arrived late, because we went to the wrong place by mistake, and then it was a bit embarrassing for me as an introvert and also because I felt bad about reaching late and disturbing the already started class.

But then, Lola was very kind to explain what we were supposed to do, showed us some examples, and we just became pairs and worked on the project. It was relaxing, and stress-free immediately once I started stitching. I did not think about perfection (I tend to be very critical of my own work and don't give myself space when I'm very invested in something, but that habit is getting less visible slowly). I could talk with others who were next to me, simple things about where we were from and what we were doing. The pairing method and presenting our partner's work was useful to team-build, to talk and create opportunities for conversation. Especially because the topic was to embroider something that was close to our heart, and getting to talk about something that is close to oneself or has value, and do that with a stranger on a very small-time span after meeting – might feel daunting when we are just speaking, for me it would have been if it was a big group of like 50 people and talking in front of them. It induces anxiety. But because the group was small and people had already started talking and were concentrating in a way that required the use of their own ideas to present their topic it was relaxing and communication friendly. At the end of the project, we got to know what people are passionate about and their values a little bit and also just a sense of achievement looking at our own creations.

P10

This was one of the most inspiring workshops out of all the activities I've participated in. I got to experience the many layers of communication involved in making crafts. First off, there was the interaction between the workshop leader, Lola, and the workshop itself. From tracing the origins of the embroidery wool to showcasing the results of previous sessions, I could really feel how deeply she understood every aspect of this workshop.

What left the biggest impression on me, though, was the group discussion about what we each wanted to embroider. It turned out to be a great icebreaker and a powerful way to open up communication. I was pleasantly surprised at how, while respecting each other's ideas, we were able to come up with a shared theme. It wasn't just a conversation starter between participants, but also a chance for us to exchange little bits of our values and worldviews.



FOREST MANDALA

The Wool Embroidery workshop was appreciated for its warm, collaborative atmosphere and its focus on personal and meaningful expression. Participants were paired to discuss their backgrounds and topics for embroidery, fostering conversations and breaking down barriers. Themes such as identity and cultural traditions often overlapped, creating connections and shared understanding among participants.

The workshop encouraged self-reflection and bonding, as partners worked together to translate personal narratives into embroidery. Many valued the opportunity to learn about others' perspectives while engaging in a hands-on, creative activity. However, some participants suggested that providing basic embroidery instructions and additional time for discussions before starting the activity would enhance the experience.

Despite varying levels of experience, participants found the activity enjoyable and stress-free, often appreciating the imperfections in their work as part of the creative process. The small group setting and personal storytelling fostered a sense of community, while the themes sparked meaningful exchanges about values and shared experiences. Many left inspired to continue exploring embroidery and crafting in their own time.

Forest Mandala

P1

I liked the moment of meditation at the beginning of the course. Sometimes we get so busy that we forget to take a moment and remember why we love nature so much. It was a great start to the activity, and I felt very comfortable using all-natural materials to make the final outdoor art installation.

P2

The workshop started with us sitting in a circle outside in the grass, and then just relaxing, feeling the sun on our faces and the grass beneath. It wasn't cold so that was a great way to relax. Then we did a short introduction about ourselves, and then we started with the mandala. We decided to make the mandala at the same place where we were sitting and then decided to go back in the trees/forest surrounding the university – so it was a nice, carefree kind of walk where people were talking about the plants, trees, mushrooms, and leaves, birds etc and then one by one we just started picking up things that were of our interest and proceeded to go to the decided place. I first thought it must be some sort of individual creation but then we just decided to make a whole big mandala with everyone's contribution. Then the ideas got changed and eventually we just added to the idea and collected more things and added to it and all the while everyone was talking, laughing, discussing things and then after the mandala was over we just sat surrounding it, had some random conversations and suddenly it was coffee time and it felt like a picnic – which was a very pleasant way to connect with strangers in an outdoor setting.

P3

I experienced community the most in the Forest Mandala and Bike Felting workshops, I believe that it was that activity, movement, using the whole body around a common task, that sparked different conversations and the experience of community in a different way than the Woven Mandala, Himmeli Craft or Mushroom Felting workshops.

In the Forest Mandala workshop, first we introduced ourselves. The workshop leader facilitated the task. After the instruction, we decided to collect different materials from nature, with which we could make a mandala. The group work worked well, others took more part in the initial planning and others had the opportunity to modify the mandala during its construction phase. We thought about form, content, colors and it was a pleasure to notice how universally we treated the subject. Meditativeness and respect for others was present in the workshop.



MUSHROOM FELTING

The Mushroom Felting workshop emerged as a favorite among participants, highlighting its relaxing and therapeutic nature. Many appreciated the opportunity to work with natural materials like raw wool, connecting to Finnish culture and nature. The hands-on craft activity allowed for creativity, collaboration, and learning from peers, fostering a warm, supportive environment.

Despite some challenges, such as difficulty with technique or lack of initial guidance for beginners, the process was engaging and meditative. Participants valued the sense of achievement in creating unique mushrooms and the communal experience of sharing techniques and final products. The setting, cozy atmosphere, and group dynamics enriched the experience, leading to discussions about sustainability, art, and personal memories.

Many noted the importance of teamwork, connection to nature, and the joy of crafting as a group. The workshop inspired some to pursue felting as a hobby or creative venture. The culminating activity of photographing the felted mushrooms outdoors was particularly rewarding, symbolizing collaboration and creativity.

Mushroom Felting

P1

As I mentioned, I don't remember ever participating in a hands-on crafts workshop before. After the fun and inspiration of the Himmeli workshop, I was excited to try felting a mushroom in my own style. The friendly atmosphere, supportive facilitator, and like-minded classmates gave me the confidence to succeed. I never imagined creating such a craft using natural resources like animal wool and turning it into something beautiful. It was true fun.

P2

The last workshop, Mushroom Felting, was the one I enjoyed the most as well, even though I struggled and failed a few times along the way, plus my final mushroom didn't look as pretty as some of the others, but the process itself was incredibly relaxing. Using my hands and reflexes to work on this activity was a refreshing change from my daily life, especially since I usually spend a lot of time working in front of a screen. I also learned from other participants who shared their tips and techniques, which made the activity feel more collaborative and helped me feel more connected to the group. Overall, it was a wonderful experience.

P3

This was definitely my favourite workshop – it was the best plan ever for a Sunday morning! Felting was very relaxing, and it was great to touch and work with wool in its raw state and understand the Finnish/Arctic culture behind the material itself. Lola was great at explaining and helping us out. I loved that we could all create something from scratch together again, and I really liked the connection to nature – felting mushrooms made me connect a previous experience of collecting mushrooms in a Finnish forest and I felt the same thing – collaborating together makes the experience way better!

P4

This was my favorite workshop. It was fun, relaxing, and I was impressed by the creativity of my colleagues. The workshop space was comfortable, and sharing our creations with one another felt really rewarding. It was a perfect way to end the entire experience.

P5

This workshop was my favourite from all of them. It was a perfect mix of fun and relaxation, to do our wool mushrooms, decorate them while having some nice conversations. I was genuinely surprised by my colleagues' creativity of the variety of mushrooms that we made. The comfortable workshop setting and the chance to share our creations made it a chill, insightful event. It was a good way to wrap up the entire experience, take some photos and place our mushrooms next to the tree near the forest that we had during the long weekend.

P6

This workshop focused on needle felting mushrooms out of wool, a practice rooted in Finnish nature. For me, this was a particularly enjoyable experience as it aligned with my own project which involves needle felting. Typically, I work alone, so it was refreshing to see how others were encountering the process for the first time, approached the task, and found joy and calm in working with natural material. During these workshops, I noticed how working in teams with nature-related activities brings up discussions about nature and sustainability. And I realized that the relaxing aspect of working with natural materials not only has an effect on us but also has a direct effect on our behavior with our teammates and finally effects on our performance.

P7

This workshop was a very enjoyable experience and I learnt a new craft which I had not tried before. The process of felting was quite relaxing and the facilitators were around to help answer any questions about the felting. I really enjoyed it when we took our mushrooms outside for a photo and saw them altogether. All the participants were visibly happy with their mushrooms and discussing the felting technique and how they found it. One piece of feedback would be to include more instruction at the start for those who never felt before to ensure that they understand the technique correctly.

P8

Even though I arrived late to the mushroom felting session, everyone welcomed me warmly. Crafting my own felt mushroom was calming, and it was inspiring to see the variety of creative designs others made. The supportive environment made it easy to join in despite my late start.

P9

This would be my second favorite workshop. It also involves wool and creating something with it. Before, I had seen videos of people doing this and I was curious about how this works, so I enjoyed having the chance to work with this. It was nice to see what others were crafting and again, having a cup of tea or coffee and some biscuits made a big difference. The venue was also cozy, and you could hear everyone having fun and sharing things about their lives. Most people were making their own mushroom but, in my case, I worked with my teammate on the same one, so we had to talk and agree on what to do next during the whole process. At the end of the day, our creation felt like our baby. When we reached the end and went all together to take pictures and see everyone's final work, everyone seemed to be in a very positive mood and having fun, even in the pictures it is possible to see that.

P10

The last of the workshops that I signed on was mushroom felting. On this one I really liked to see different approaches to participants' works. Some tried to recreate the mushroom completely, while others did simplified, nearly cartoonish depictions of it. It was also one of the more relaxing workshops, as you also could work on your project by yourself in the cozy setting of the sauna room.

P11

On the last day, we felted mushrooms. Again, I was excited, because I love crafting. We got inspiration from real finish mushrooms and started poking the wool. It was really calming and nice work. Of course I poked my fingertips a few times, but that is part of it. Here I would say the same issue occurred: There was not enough interaction between the group members, at least from my perspective. The workshop should have had some kind of teamwork.

P12

This might have been my favorite part of all the activities. What blows my mind is how simple the process is but how wonderfully satisfying the outcome can be. I picked it up really quickly and even managed to make a second mushroom at home. My only wish was that this activity could have lasted for two days, not just one.

P13

Felting was very relaxing, and we shared a compact space and tools as a group. I had fallen before, so it was nice to help my neighbors. It was great to use raw wool again as well as naturally dyed wool. The smell of wool was very intoxicating. They say time flies when you're comfortable, and that was the case with this one. The felting and scratching could have continued indefinitely. All in all, during the last few days, I have noticed that, for example, crafts are a really good way to cultivate group spirit and do things together. I hadn't done handicrafts in a long time, especially with soft materials, so the workshops were relaxing and at the same time I noticed that I also learned something new. It must be said that practicing handicrafts under natural conditions or with the most durable materials is not that complicated. How could even these fairly simple workshops be implemented using the most durable materials? So we have years of heritage from organic methods, so it was nice how they were utilized in this course/workshop as a whole. Organizing more sustainable workshops is therefore not impossible, and hopefully we will see more of them in the future. We hope that similar projects will be funded in the future.

P14

The workshop started indoors in a warm room, with everyone surrounding the tables. I have never done felting before and I did not even know what it was, so it was a genuinely surprising and good experience that at the end of the workshop I actually had a mushroom in my hands.

Because there were people sitting next to me who knew what felting was, they helped me with the basics and then we just went from there while talking to each other, and because we had kinda made a rapport over the few workshops we had before it was a lovely experience doing our own individual work and at the same time discuss different subjects and things. It was also my first time smelling raw wool, and I was surprised. I never thought it would be like that considering the woollen clothes I wore as a child – which now I feel weren't real enough. It felt funny relating it to a memory of my childhood.

All in all it was a great experience and I did find something that I could do as a side business or just something in my art.

P15

In the Mushroom Felting workshop, which was the last workshop, the fatigue of the participants started to show a little through the argumentation. Needle felting at the tables sparked a discussion among the felters about music, their own culture, food and how sharp the felting needles were. We felt success, when the wool began to resemble the shape of a mushroom. Creating a mushroom army under the birches crowned the end of the workshop.

P16

In this workshop, I discovered a new passion for felting. It's a fascinating craft so simple in concept, just poking with a needle, yet so versatile, quickly evolving into complex skills for shaping 3D objects. The structure and instructions were well executed, making it a relaxing and meditative activity. I think craft workshops, in general, are excellent for fostering communication and collaboration. There's something magical about sharing experiences and achieving something together. It was also interesting to observe how participants influenced each other by watching what others were doing. What I appreciate about this is how innovation happens more through action and practice than words.

P17

This was by far the most relaxed workshop I've taken part in. Repeatedly poking wool felt is such a therapeutic process that it put me in a really peaceful state of mind. Mushroom Felting was quite different from Bike Felting. The former is more straightforward, you just feel wool into the shape of a mushroom, and there's also mushroom-dyed yarn you can use. But the focus was really on introducing us to the mushrooms that pop up all over Finland during the summer. Bike Felting, on the other hand, was more unexpected. The bike acts as a modern-day substitute for horses, a practical tool for knowledge production, rather than just an object of aesthetic creation. So, Mushroom Felting naturally created a lighter, more playful atmosphere.

I especially loved how one of my classmates suggested that we place all the felted mushrooms we made around a big tree outdoors. We ended up gathering around the tree like the mushrooms we had made and took a group photo. My mood at that moment was as bright as the weather. This workshop also made me realize that I tend to follow my inner visions when I create.

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Those responsible for concept and coordination

- **Lola Cervantes** is an artist, researcher and designer from Mexico, PhD Student Lapland University
- **Maria Huhmarniemi** is an artist, researcher and associate professor from Finland, she seeks to enhance sustainability through creativity, transculturalism and education.
- **Igor Vitale** is a Psychologist expert in gastronomical and agricultural approach in education for vocational training.
- **Mahmoud ElSayed** is a passionate intercultural trainer who carried out various activities in so many topics including (inclusion, digital skills, rural development for youth and agritourism business development for entrepreneurs).

Your group of researchers

- **Mairella Segreti** - PhD student in Behavioral Neuroscience at “La Sapienza” university of Rome
- **Agnese Gobbi** - bachelor's degree in psychology, currently studying for masters.
- **Suvi Autio** is an artist-art teacher from Finland. She is interested in the political aspects of art, place based art and media art as tools for transformation and reflection.

The writers behind the impact report

- **Mariella Segreti**

The designers of the impact report

- **Mahmoud ElSayed**

Your contributors

- **Oussama Ben Abda** based in Berlin and originally from Tunisia and working on his Vocational Training in hotel management and services.
- **Romain Van Staden** obtained his BTech (Environmental Health) at CPUT (then Peninsula Technikon). I practiced as an EHP at a local authority in the Northern Cape.
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